Mesa School of Business

The Productivity Leverage Challenge

Student Brief | Find the work worth changing. Decide how. Build the proof.

Read this before you touch a tool.

We are not asking you to automate a problem. We are asking you to diagnose a situation, judge what should change, and build the proof that you were right.

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(1) What this looks like

An example situation (not one of your challenges):

> Feedback about a programme arrives every term from five places — student forms, mentor notes, a WhatsApp group, emails to the coordinator and exit conversations — in different formats, at different times, owned by nobody end to end. Leadership wants a sense of what is happening on the ground, but by the time feedback is compiled the term is over. Strong signals get noticed only when someone raises them twice.

Every one of these is a legitimate build from that one situation. Which is right depends entirely on your diagnosis:

- **A summariser of five fragmented sources into one themed digest** — if nobody can see the whole picture.
- **A severity classifier** that surfaces only this week's actions — if the problem is volume, not visibility.
- **A response assistant that drafts replies to those who gave feedback** — if feedback dies because nobody closes the loop.
- **A routing workflow that sends each item to whoever can act on it** — if nobody owns it.
- **A redesign of how feedback is collected** with very little AI in it — if the inputs are broken.

All five are defensible — but none without the diagnosis. We are not looking for the right answer. We are looking for a defended one.

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(2) Your problem is not too small

If your problem feels small, go deeper rather than swapping it for a bigger one. We score how far you went into the idea, not its size:

Solved at the surface	Solved with depth
Tags each message professional or personal. Two buckets, fixed rules, no judgment inside.	Tags it, then classifies what it demands — a decision, a reply, a delegation, a follow-up, or nothing — and can explain why one item ranked above another.

Solved at the surface	Solved with depth
Ends at classification. The user still opens everything to work out what to do.	Drafts replies where needed, routes what belongs to someone else, tracks what has not come back and resurfaces it.
Human involvement not considered. Proof is "it ran".	Nothing goes out without approval; it states its confidence. Proof is what would have been missed without it, on messy data.

(3) The journey

Situation → Workflow → 2–3 Opportunities → Choose ONE → Choose Intervention → Define MVP → Build → Prove

- **Situation:** who is involved, what they are trying to do, what has been asked for.
- **Workflow:** map it step by step today, including handoffs — before you have any ideas.
- **Opportunities:** 2–3 things that could be improved, with the evidence pointing to each.
- **Choose one:** pick the one worth solving and say why it beat the others.
- **Intervene:** what changes about the work; what the system does versus the person. Not everything should be AI. Argue against two rejected alternatives.
- **MVP:** the smallest thing that would prove your decision, and what you leave out.
- **Build and prove:** make it run, and show what would have been missed without it.

(4) Schedule and rules

Time	What you are doing	Due
1.15 hrs	Brief and challenge allocation. Diagnose + Decide. No building in this window.	Submission 1
2.45 hrs	Implementation and building	Submission 2
Next day	Showcase for the strongest teams	Presentation + Q&A

- **One assigned challenge per team. No swapping.**
- **Do not start building before Submission 1. The first hour is where most of your score is decided.**
- **Use any tools you like. Available: Gumloop, Claude, Replit, n8n, Gemini API.**
- **Mentors will challenge your reasoning before they help you build. That is intentional.**

(5) Submission 1: Diagnose + Decide — 75%

Made in the Excel template provided, which carries a worked example and the scoring descriptors for every section.

Section	What to show	Weight
Situation, user and current workflow	Who is involved, what they are trying to accomplish, and how the work happens today step by step including the handoffs.	15%
2–3 opportunities	What could be improved, and the evidence or symptom that points to each.	15%
Intervention and rationale	Which opportunity you chose and why it beat the others; what changes about the work; what the system does versus the person; two rejected alternatives; what you keep human.	20%
MVP	Input, process, output, human checkpoint, success metric, and what is excluded.	15%
Risks and assumptions	What could go wrong, what it would cost, and which assumption most needs testing.	10%

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(6) Submission 2: Build — 25%

A working MVP, a two-minute video and a link.

Working MVP and core functionality 10% · Quality of automation and implementation 5% · Usability and practical value 5% · Demo and communication 5%

Strong means: it runs end to end on realistic inputs including one messy case; the workflow is genuinely wired together, not one prompt with the real work done manually around it; the user could pick it up unaided; and the demo runs situation → diagnosis → decision → proof in under two minutes.

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(7) Questions your mentors and judges will ask

If you cannot answer these, you are not ready to build.

- **What is actually broken in the workflow, and who feels the pain?**
- **What else did you consider, and why did you choose this one?**
- **Why this intervention, what stays human, and what if it is wrong?**
- **What is the smallest proof, and what would you measure after?**

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(8) Showcase

- **Thinking — 2 min:** situation → diagnosis → selected problem → decision → why.

- **Demo — 5 min:** working prototype and output.
- **Q&A — 3 min:** Your batch as the judge - they test your judgment, risk handling, human involvement and next steps.

The story we want to hear: *"Here was the situation. We found these opportunities. We chose this one because _____. We decided to [intervention] because _____. Here is the smallest MVP that proves our decision."*

AI leverage starts with understanding the work, not with opening a tool.